

Versailles

Starting life as an extension of Louis XIII's hunting lodge in 1623, the Palace of Versailles was built for Louis XIV, the 'Sun King', from 1668 to 1710. The main architects were Louis le Vau (1612–70) and Hardouin-Mansart, whose many collaborators included landscape architect André Le Nôtre (1613–1700) and painter Charles Le Brun (1619–90). Versailles grew into one of the world's largest palaces, the summit of French baroque, embodying the absolutism of the monarchy. Standing more than 400 metres (1,300 ft) long, the palace takes the form of a grand central block and two flanking wings set around a central courtyard. The complex includes five chapels, the Grand Trianon (1687–8), the Pavillon Français (1749) and the Petit Trianon (1762–8). The Hall of Mirrors (Galerie des Glaces), the palace's glittering central gallery, is one of the most famous rooms in the world. The palace, its decoration and extensive grounds stimulated a rebirth of decorative art. From 1682 to 1789, approximately 3,000 people, including the king and the entire French royal court, lived at Versailles.

